

Arthritis and Sleep Problems: How to Get Better Rest with Jo

Struggling to sleep with arthritis? Evidence-based guide to improving sleep quality when living with joint pain. Includes sleep positions, mattress advice and UK resources.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-17 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Person sleeping peacefully in bed with supportive pillows for arthritis comfort
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Sleep and arthritis have a complex, bidirectional relationship: arthritis pain disrupts sleep, and poor sleep makes arthritis pain worse. Studies suggest that **up to 80%** of

people with arthritis experience some form of sleep disturbance, ranging from difficulty falling asleep to frequent night-time awakening and non-restorative sleep. In the UK, where arthritis affects over 10 million people, the impact of poor sleep on quality of life is enormous. This comprehensive guide explores why arthritis affects sleep, provides evidence-based strategies for improving sleep quality, and offers practical advice on everything from sleeping positions to mattress selection.

Why Arthritis Affects Sleep

Pain and Discomfort

The most obvious barrier to sleep is pain. Joint pain can make it difficult to find a comfortable sleeping position, and any movement during the night — turning over, adjusting your pillow, getting up to use the bathroom — can trigger sharp pain that jolts you awake. For people with osteoarthritis, night-time pain is often associated with inflammation that builds during the day, reaching peak levels in the evening and early hours.

Inflammatory Cytokines

The body's inflammatory processes follow circadian rhythms. In inflammatory types of arthritis (rheumatoid arthritis, psoriatic arthritis), pro-inflammatory cytokines like TNF- α and IL-6 peak during the early morning hours, which explains why morning stiffness is often severe. These same cytokines interfere with sleep architecture, disrupting deep sleep stages and REM sleep. Research published in *Sleep Medicine Reviews* confirms that elevated inflammatory markers are independently associated with poorer sleep quality.

Medication Effects

Some arthritis medications can affect sleep. Corticosteroids (prednisolone) can cause insomnia if taken late in the day. Certain painkillers may cause drowsiness during the day, disrupting normal sleep-wake cycles. DMARD medications can sometimes cause fatigue that leads to daytime napping, which then impairs night-time sleep.

Psychological Factors

Living with chronic pain increases the risk of anxiety and depression, both of which are strongly associated with insomnia. The worry about another bad night's sleep can itself create

a self-fulfilling prophecy — a phenomenon known as sleep-related anxiety or conditioned insomnia.

Optimising Your Sleep Environment



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Choosing the Right Mattress

A supportive mattress is crucial for joint comfort during sleep. While individual preferences vary, research and expert opinion suggest:

- Medium-firm mattresses generally provide the best balance of support and pressure relief for arthritis patients. A study in The Lancet found medium-firm mattresses reduced pain and disability more than firm mattresses in people with back pain

- Memory foam or hybrid mattresses conform to body contours, distributing pressure more evenly and reducing stress on painful joints
- Mattress toppers can improve an existing mattress without the cost of replacement — memory foam toppers (5–8cm thick) are widely available in the UK from £30–£100
- Replace your mattress every 7–10 years, or sooner if it's sagging or no longer supportive
- Many UK mattress companies (Emma, Simba, Tempur) offer trial periods of 100–200 nights, allowing you to test the mattress at home

Pillow Selection

- Use a pillow that keeps your neck aligned with your spine — not too high, not too flat
- Memory foam contour pillows are popular for neck support
- Place a pillow between your knees when sleeping on your side to reduce hip and lower back strain
- For hand arthritis, a small pillow or rolled towel supporting the wrist can reduce morning stiffness

Room Conditions

- Temperature — A cool room (16–18°C) is optimal for sleep, but ensure joints are kept warm under bedding. Consider an electric blanket (used before bed to pre-warm, then switched off) or bed socks
- Darkness — Use blackout curtains or a sleep mask to maximise melatonin production
- Quiet — Earplugs or a white noise machine can block disruptive sounds
- Screen-free zone — Remove phones and tablets from the bedroom, or use blue-light filters in the hour before bed

Best Sleeping Positions for Arthritis

For Knee Arthritis

- Sleep on your back with a pillow under your knees to reduce pressure
- If side sleeping, place a firm pillow between your knees to keep hips aligned
- Avoid sleeping with knees fully bent, which can increase stiffness

For Hip Arthritis

- Sleep on the unaffected side with a pillow between your knees
- A body pillow or pregnancy pillow provides full-length support
- If sleeping on your back, place a pillow under your knees and a thin one under the small of your back

For Shoulder Arthritis

- Avoid sleeping on the affected shoulder
- When lying on your back, support the affected arm on a pillow
- A reclining position (using an adjustable bed or wedge pillow) can reduce shoulder pressure

For Spinal Arthritis

- A medium-firm mattress is essential for spinal support
- Sleeping on your back with a pillow under your knees is generally best
- If side sleeping, use a firm pillow that fills the gap between your shoulder and ear to keep the spine aligned
- Avoid sleeping on your stomach, which can strain the neck and lower back

Sleep Hygiene Strategies



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- Consistent schedule — Go to bed and wake up at the same time every day, even on weekends
- Wind-down routine — Spend 30–60 minutes before bed doing calming activities: reading, gentle stretching, warm bath, listening to music or a podcast
- Limit caffeine — No caffeine after 2pm (remember that tea, chocolate and cola contain caffeine too)
- Alcohol — While alcohol may help you fall asleep initially, it disrupts sleep quality later in the night and can increase inflammation
- Evening exercise timing — Finish moderate exercise at least 3 hours before bed. Gentle stretching is fine closer to bedtime

- Manage pain before bed — Take evening pain medication 30–60 minutes before sleep. Apply heat packs to stiff joints. Do gentle range-of-motion exercises
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When to Seek Help

Speak to your GP if sleep problems persist despite implementing these strategies. Options include medication review, referral for cognitive behavioural therapy for insomnia (CBT-I — available on the NHS and through the free NHS app Sleepio), assessment for sleep apnoea (which is more common in people with arthritis due to weight and medication factors), and possible referral to a pain clinic for comprehensive pain management.

Quality sleep is not a luxury — it's a fundamental part of managing arthritis effectively. By addressing your sleep environment, routine and pain management, you can break the cycle of poor sleep and increased pain. Our virtual assistant can suggest a personalised bedtime routine for your specific joints.

This article is for general information only. Consult your GP for advice tailored to your situation.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis and sleep problems: how to get better rest with jo?

Short answer: Arthritis pain, inflammatory cytokines, and medication side effects can disrupt sleep. To improve sleep, ensure your mattress is medium-firm with good support, replace it every 7–10 years, and use pillows for spinal alignment. Sleep in a cool room (16–18°C), maintain a consistent sleep schedule, and create a calm wind-down routine. Avoid caffeine after 2 pm and time pain relief before bed.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk